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Assembly disrupted by protesters against Israel-Hamas war

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Protesters calling for a cease-fire in the Israel-Hamas war on Wednesdayshut down the California Assembly on the Legislature's first Capitol floor session of the new year.

Hundreds of demonstrators from Jewish anti-war organizations packed the Rotunda and the Assembly gallery and began chanting, singing and unveiling banners around 1:30 p.m., just as lawmakers reconvened in Sacramento after a months-long recess.

The Assembly was conducting routine business and recessed during the protests before adjourning for the day. The Senate, which convened at 2 p.m., met without disruption.

The protesters were from groups that included Jewish Voices for Peace, IfNotNow and the International Jewish Anti-Zionist Network.

Demonstrators' banners read, "Jews say not in our name," "Jews say no U.S. funding for Israel's genocide in Palestine" and "Jews say California tax $$$ for healthcare, housing, schools, climate."

Protesters in the Capitol

Protesters sang "cease-fire" as lawmakers began leaving the chamber, although a few lingered on the floor and in the back of the room. None of the CHP sergeants who provide security at the Capitol removed or arrested any of the demonstrators, who continued singing and chanting to a largely empty room.

They remained even after the lights in the Assembly chamber were shut off, continuing to sing while turning on their cellphone flashlights.

The protesters said, "Jewish values bring us here to say no to California money for genocide."

"Assembly members, we call on you to join us in calling for cease-fire now," they said in unison.

"I know that the world abandoned Jewish people during the Holocaust, but our safety is not dependent on oppressing others," said Margot Goldstein, a San Francisco-based teacher taking part in the demonstration.

"The fascism that we faced in Nazi Germany and around the world is what leads me to understand that what is happening now is a genocide, and that my history should not be used to excuse that or defend that."

Goldstein said she wants California lawmakers - and Gov. Gavin Newsom, who has supported Israel - to "listen to progressive Jews."

Rotunda protest

Protesters sat in the Rotunda after they disrupted the Assembly. They chanted and sang, and some leaders gave speeches.

Sacramento City Councilwoman Katie Valenzuela spoke in support of a ceasefire.

"I think it's important to show elected officials that other elected officials are using our platform, and we're okay," she told The Sacramento Bee before she spoke.

"It's okay to come out, and it's okay to use your platform. I feel like it's important not just to show my community and my constituents, many of whom are here today, that I stand with them -- but it's also important to use my platform to get other elected officials to join us."

Valenzuela said she loves her Jewish neighbors and Sacramento's Jewish community.

"It's out of love for that community that I'm here today," she said. "I don't think this (war) is making anybody safe ... I believe the only path forward that includes safety for the Jewish community is one that is peaceful, and that doesn't rely on the suppression of Palestinian neighbors."

She said her support of a ceasefire is not support for Hamas' actions on Oct. 7.

"I think the actions taken in October in Israel are horrific, and I think the actions taken in Gaza since then are also horrific."

The demonstration occurred as Assembly Republicans were preparing to introduce a resolution condemning Hamas as one of their first acts of the new legislative year.

The conflict has divided Democrats, with moderates generally supporting Israel and progressives calling for a cease-fire.

Legislative Jewish Caucus co-chairs Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, and Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, said they disapproved of the protesters' disruptions because "shutting down the democratic process is not a good thing."

They emphasized the fear the Jewish community is experiencing as a result of the antisemitism that has followed the Oct. 7 attacks and the war in Gaza. All told, more than 22,000 Palestinians have been killed in Gaza since the conflict began; about 700 Israeli civilians were killed during the initial attack nearly three months ago.

"We've made very clear what our perspective is in the caucus," Wiener said. "We have our own criticisms of Israel. We want the war to end. The death that happened in Israel, and the death that's happening in Gaza is just horrific."

"We also know that the cease-fire resolutions we've seen at the local level have, at times, gone off the rails in terms of dredging up a lot of anti-Jewish hate," he added. "And that causes a lot of fear in our community for a non-binding resolution."

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